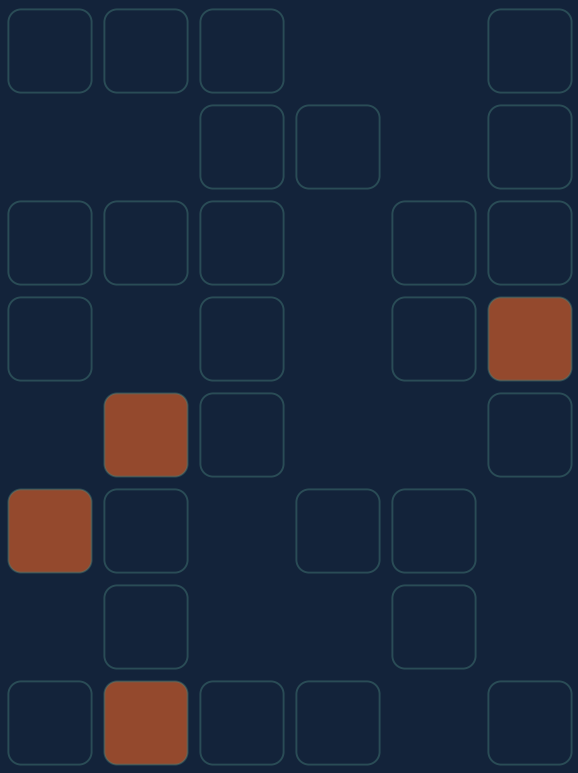
THE LSI TOOLKIT



TOOL 01 OF 04 · PROCESS GUIDE

The Process to Solicit a Learning Space Integrator

A Qualifications-Based Procurement Guide for School Districts

learningspaceintegrator.com · Version 2.0 · 2026

Industry Standard Template • Not affiliated with any vendor or proprietary methodology

This guide walks school districts through a qualifications-based process for selecting a Learning Space Integrator (LSI) — a firm that helps design, procure, and implement integrated learning environments. The process evaluates firms on their experience, methodology, and fit with your district's educational vision — not primarily on price. This is an industry-standard template. It is not affiliated with any specific vendor, methodology, or proprietary framework.

How to Use This Toolkit

The LSI Toolkit has four tools, used in order:

Tool	Name	Use it to...
01	Process Guide (this document)	Plan the full selection process, from team assembly to project kickoff
02	RFQ Template	Issue a ready-to-customize Request for Qualifications
03	Evaluation Scorecard	Score proposals consistently against nine weighted criteria (Excel calculator included)
04	Finalist Interview Guide	Run fair, structured finalist interviews and reference checks

LSI TOOLKIT · 01 PROCESS GUIDE

Quick Orientation: What Is an LSI and Why This Matters

What Is a Learning Space Integrator?

A Learning Space Integrator (LSI) is a specialized consulting firm that helps school districts design, procure, and implement integrated learning environments. An LSI manages the process from educational vision through implementation — from furniture and technology to professional development — with the goal of creating spaces that support your district's specific learning goals.

What an LSI does	What an LSI is NOT
Assesses your district's current learning environment and educational vision	A general contractor or construction firm
Designs physical spaces aligned with your pedagogical approach	A single-vendor furniture or technology dealer representing one product line
Manages procurement of all components across multiple vendors	A general consultant with no specialized expertise in learning environments
Coordinates implementation and teacher professional development	
Provides ongoing support to ensure the environment serves your learning goals	

What Are Integrated Learning Environments?

Integrated learning environments go beyond furniture selection. They are spaces where the physical environment, technology, and pedagogical approach work together to support the way your district wants students to learn. Key principles include:

- **Flexible spaces** that can adapt to different learning modes — individual work, small-group collaboration, large-group instruction
- **Integrated technology** that is part of the learning process rather than bolted on
- **Vision-first design** that begins with your educational vision, not a product catalog
- **School- or building-specific scoping** so each site is planned and accountable individually
- **Universal design and accessibility:** spaces that work for all learners — including students with disabilities, sensory differences, and varied learning needs
- **Measurable, appropriate outcomes:** how will you know the space is working? Think utilization, educator adoption, instructional practice change, and perception — not standardized test scores, which are not a valid measure of learning environment effectiveness

Why Use a Qualifications-Based Process?

Traditional competitive bidding selects vendors based primarily on price. For complex, vision-driven projects like learning environment design, that approach produces spaces that may not align with your pedagogy, face poor teacher adoption, and ultimately waste resources.

A qualifications-based selection process evaluates firms on experience, methodology, and fit with your district — before price is the deciding factor. This produces:

- A partner who understands your educational vision, not just your budget
- Cohesive learning environments where space, technology, and teaching all work together
- Clearer accountability at every school and project site

- Better long-term value, because the right partner delivers results

Two Procurement Pathways: RFQ vs. RFP

Qualifications-based procurement for LSI services can take two valid forms. Your district should decide which pathway to use before issuing the solicitation, document that decision, and apply it consistently.

RFQ — Request for Qualifications	RFP — Request for Proposals
How it works: Firms are ranked solely on qualifications. Price is not part of the initial evaluation. After the most qualified firm is identified, the district negotiates fees directly with that firm.	**How it works:** Firms submit a technical proposal and a fee proposal simultaneously. Both are evaluated together using predetermined weights. The firm offering the best overall value — not the lowest price — is selected.
Best when: The project scope is complex or not fully defined; the district wants to co-develop the scope with the selected partner before pricing; or qualifications alignment is the primary driver.	**Best when:** The scope is well defined; the district wants price to be a formal part of the selection (typically 10–25% of the total score); or board or state policy requires it.
Key step: If fee negotiation fails with the top-ranked firm, the district negotiates with the second-ranked firm. Document this process carefully.	**Key requirement:** Weights for technical and price components must be predetermined and disclosed in the solicitation. Do not give price more weight than the technical evaluation for LSI services.

> Either pathway is valid. The key is consistency: choose before issuing, publish the pathway in the solicitation, and do not change it after proposals are received. Consult your Purchasing Director and Legal Counsel to confirm which pathway is appropriate under your state's procurement statutes.

Phase 1: Prepare Your District

> Before you issue a solicitation, you need to identify key stakeholders, secure leadership buy-in, and establish your selection criteria. Skipping this phase leads to misaligned proposals and poor selection decisions.

Action 1.1: Assemble Your Team

Who needs to be in the room (or on the committee)?

- Superintendent or Chief Academic Officer (executive sponsor)
- Director of Purchasing / Procurement (required for legal and compliance review)
- District Legal Counsel (reviews solicitation language and the final contract)
- Project Architect (aligns with the physical building)
- Director of Curriculum & Instruction (educational vision)
- Building Principal or Instructional Leader (implementation reality)
- Director of Facilities (space and logistics)
- Special Education Director or Inclusion Lead (accessibility requirements)
- Technology Director or IT Lead (digital ecosystem)
- Finance Director or Budget Manager (cost management)
- One or two respected teachers (pedagogy and classroom reality)
- Student representatives or a student advisory group — include student voice in visioning and early design review wherever possible

Why: Diverse perspectives produce fair evaluations. Including Purchasing and Legal from the start keeps the process legally defensible and compliant with your state's procurement statutes. Including student voice reflects that the spaces being designed are for students — not just adults.

CHECKLIST — ACTION 1.1

- [ ] Identify and invite all stakeholders to the first meeting
- [ ] Schedule a regular cadence (weekly or bi-weekly during procurement)
- [ ] Assign a project lead or committee chair
- [ ] Confirm the Purchasing Director and Legal Counsel are engaged
- [ ] Document meeting notes and decisions

Action 1.2: Verify Compliance with State Procurement Law

Before you issue any procurement document, verify that your approach complies with your state's statutes. Requirements vary significantly by state, including:

- Dollar thresholds that trigger formal competitive procurement
- Whether qualifications-based selection (QBS) is permitted for consulting services in your state
- Cooperative purchasing programs your district participates in (TIPS/TAPS, Sourcewell, OMNIA Partners, E&I Cooperative, or state-specific cooperatives) — these may allow you to access pre-vetted vendors without a separate solicitation
- Public notice requirements for issuing the solicitation
- Required protest and appeal procedures

> **Note on cooperative purchasing:** If your district participates in a cooperative purchasing program, check whether a suitable LSI contract already exists on that vehicle. If it does, you may be able to proceed directly to vendor selection without issuing a new RFQ. Consult your Purchasing Director and Legal Counsel.

CHECKLIST — ACTION 1.2

- [ ] Confirm state procurement law requirements with Legal Counsel
- [ ] Check cooperative purchasing programs for existing LSI contracts
- [ ] Determine whether public notice is required, and when
- [ ] Confirm the protest/appeal process and document it

Action 1.3: Secure Leadership Buy-In

You cannot run a serious LSI selection without committed leadership support. What you need:

- A leadership statement (superintendent or board resolution) endorsing the initiative
- Timeline approval from the superintendent or board
- Clear authority for the selection committee
- Board approval, if required by your district for this contract type or size

CHECKLIST — ACTION 1.3

- [ ] Get board approval (if required)
- [ ] Secure written commitment from the executive sponsor
- [ ] Document the decision and approved timeline

Phase 2: Develop and Issue the RFQ

> Your district should already have decided whether to use an RFQ (qualifications first, negotiate price after) or an RFP (qualifications and price evaluated together with predetermined weights). The process in this phase applies to both — the key difference is whether the fee proposal is submitted with the technical proposal (RFP) or negotiated afterward (RFQ).

Action 2.1: Develop Your Scope of Work — School by School

The scope of work answers: what are we asking the LSI to do, and for which specific schools or buildings?

A key principle of effective LSI procurement is that work should be scoped and evaluated school by school or project by project, not as a single district-wide contract. This means:

- Each school or building is treated as a separate scope with its own timeline, deliverables, and accountability
- Firms must demonstrate the capacity and process to manage each site independently
- The district can phase work across buildings without obligating the full scope upfront
- If a firm underperforms on one school, it is identifiable and correctable before the next site begins

Typical LSI scope includes:

- Educational assessment and visioning (what learning do we want to support at each site?)
- Space design and layout planning — by building
- Technology ecosystem planning
- Furniture and equipment recommendations
- Vendor management and procurement
- Implementation planning and project management — site by site
- Teacher training and change management
- Budget management within approved amounts per project
- Post-implementation support and evaluation

CHECKLIST — ACTION 2.1

- [ ] Draft the scope of work (2–3 pages), organized by school or building
- [ ] Clarify what is in scope and out of scope for each site
- [ ] Define timeline and milestones per school or project
- [ ] Get procurement team feedback on the scope document

Action 2.2: Define Your Evaluation Criteria

You will use these criteria to compare LSI proposals. The Evaluation Scorecard (Tool 03) provides the full nine-criteria rubric:

#	Criterion Area	Weight (set before issuing)
1	Relevant Experience & Past Performance	_____ %
2	Educational / Learning Environment Approach	_____ %
3	Stakeholder Engagement & Discovery	_____ %
4	Design & Planning Methodology	_____ %
5	Implementation & Project Management	_____ %
6	Budget, Cost Transparency & Value	_____ %
7	Product Sourcing & Procurement Transparency	_____ %
8	Partnership, Governance & Communication	_____ %
9	Outcomes, Evaluation & Continuous Improvement	_____ %

Your committee assigns a weight to each criterion before the solicitation is issued. Weights must total 100% and must be disclosed in the solicitation. See the Scorecard for suggested starting weights and guidance on adapting them to your district's priorities.

> **Note on vendor transparency:** Rather than treating vendor independence as a pass/fail requirement, require all proposers to fully disclose any financial relationships, ownership interests, or referral arrangements with furniture, technology, or materials vendors. Criterion 7 (Product Sourcing & Procurement Transparency) evaluates the quality and completeness of this disclosure. See the RFQ Template for the required disclosure language.

CHECKLIST — ACTION 2.2

- [ ] Review the Evaluation Scorecard for detailed criteria
- [ ] Adapt criteria weights to your district's priorities (before scoring; apply uniformly to all proposals)
- [ ] Document and publish the final criteria before issuing the RFQ

Action 2.3: Create the RFQ Document

The RFQ is the formal document you send to LSI firms. The RFQ Template (Tool 02) is a complete, ready-to-customize document. Key sections include:

- Cover letter (who you are, what you are doing, why it matters)

- Educational vision and district context
- Project scope — organized by school or building
- Conflict of interest disclosure requirement
- Evaluation criteria
- Proposal requirements and format
- Contact information, question deadline, and submission deadline
- Equal opportunity and non-discrimination statement

CHECKLIST — ACTION 2.3

- [ ] Use the RFQ Template as your starting point
- [ ] Customize it with your vision, scope (school by school), and criteria
- [ ] Have the Purchasing Director and Legal Counsel review for compliance
- [ ] Set a realistic deadline (4–6 weeks is typical)
- [ ] Designate who will receive submissions and answer questions

Action 2.4: Build Your Prospect List

Research approach:

- Ask your architect, facilities planner, or peer districts for referrals
- Search online for "learning space integrator," "learning environment consultants," or "educational space integrators"
- Reach out to professional associations such as the Association for Learning Environments (A4LE)
- Ask your superintendent's network for districts that have completed similar projects
- Review your cooperative purchasing program for pre-qualified firms

Vetting approach (before sending the RFQ):

- **Website and case studies:** Do they show evidence of relevant K-12 work?
- **References:** Have they worked with districts of similar size and context?
- **Team:** Do they have relevant experience in educational design and implementation?
- **Capacity:** Are they available for your timeline?

Invite three to five firms to submit. Too few limits your options; too many makes evaluation unwieldy.

CHECKLIST — ACTION 2.4

- [ ] Research at least 5–10 potential LSI firms
- [ ] Narrow to 3–5 based on fit and capacity
- [ ] Prepare the invitation package (RFQ + cover letter)
- [ ] Send invitations and request confirmation of interest

Action 2.5: Manage the Question Period

Once firms have the RFQ, they will ask questions. This is normal and important for fair competition.

- Set a clear deadline for questions (typically 1–2 weeks before the proposal deadline)
- Collect all questions in writing (email only)
- Answer in writing and share all questions and answers with every invited firm — not just the one who asked
- Post the Q&A on your website or send it to all firms on the same date
- Do not answer questions submitted after the deadline

CHECKLIST — ACTION 2.5

- [ ] Set the question deadline and state it in the RFQ
- [ ] Collect all questions in one place
- [ ] Draft answers as a team (involve Purchasing and Legal as needed)
- [ ] Share the Q&A with all invited firms simultaneously

Phase 3: Receive and Evaluate Proposals

Action 3.1: Establish Evaluation Protocols

Before proposals arrive, prepare the team for fair, consistent evaluation.

Element	Standard
Evaluation team	5–7 people from your procurement committee
Evaluation rubric	The criteria and weights defined in Phase 2 (see the Evaluation Scorecard)
Individual evaluation	Each evaluator scores each proposal independently before group discussion
Consensus process	The team discusses scores and reaches consensus
Documentation	Record why proposals scored as they did — this record protects the district if a firm protests

Fair evaluation practices:

- Each evaluator reads each proposal completely before scoring
- Evaluators score independently before discussing with others
- Discussion focuses on the published criteria — not personal impressions
- Ties are resolved by the committee chair
- All evaluators sign a conflict of interest certification before scoring

CHECKLIST — ACTION 3.1

- [ ] Assemble the evaluation team (5–7 people)
- [ ] Collect signed conflict of interest certifications from all evaluators
- [ ] Share the scorecard and evaluation criteria with the team
- [ ] Brief the team on fair evaluation practices and bias traps
- [ ] Schedule the evaluation meeting (plan for 4–6 hours)

Action 3.2: Score Proposals Using the Scorecard

1. Each evaluator reads the full proposal independently
2. Each evaluator completes the scorecard for each proposal
3. The team meets to discuss proposals criterion by criterion
4. The team reaches consensus on the score for each criterion
5. Final score = weighted sum of all criteria
6. Identify the top 2–3 finalists for reference checks and interviews

CHECKLIST — ACTION 3.2

- [ ] Each evaluator reads all proposals completely
- [ ] Each evaluator completes independent scoring for all proposals
- [ ] The team meets to discuss and reach consensus scores
- [ ] Document final scores and notes for all proposals
- [ ] Identify the top 2–3 finalists

Action 3.3: Conduct Reference Checks

Before finalist interviews, contact the references provided by top-scoring firms. The Finalist Interview Guide (Tool 04) includes a full reference check form.

What to ask:

- What was your working relationship with this firm? Which staff did you work with most closely?
- How was the firm to work with? (Communication, responsiveness, collaboration?)
- Did they deliver what they promised — on time, on budget, at the quality expected?
- How would you describe the outcomes — how did the space change how teachers and students worked?
- What would you do differently if you could do it again?
- Would you hire this firm again? Why or why not?
- Can you share photos or arrange a site visit?

Who to call: references from similar-sized districts, from districts with comparable project scope, and, if possible, from districts in your region.

CHECKLIST — ACTION 3.3

- [ ] Call all references provided by each finalist
- [ ] Document reference feedback in writing
- [ ] Ask for site visit opportunities if available
- [ ] Share reference notes with the full evaluation team

Action 3.4: Hold Finalist Interviews

The Finalist Interview Guide (Tool 04) provides the full interview structure, question bank, and logistics checklist. In summary:

- Invite your top 2–3 finalists to a 60–90 minute interview
- Use a consistent format and question set for all finalists
- Have the same committee members present for all interviews
- Ask each finalist to walk through how they would approach your specific project — school by school
- Document notes from each interview; debrief as a team after all interviews are complete

Action 3.5: Make Your Final Selection

After scoring, reference checks, and interviews:

- If one firm scored significantly higher across all criteria, the decision is clear
- If two firms are close, focus on the differentiators: which better understands your vision? Which team would you want to partner with for two or more years? Which demonstrated stronger school-by-school accountability?
- Trust the process — you built good criteria and scored consistently
- Document your selection rationale in writing before notification

CHECKLIST — ACTION 3.5

- [ ] Review final scores with the full procurement team
- [ ] Discuss any close calls or tied scores by criterion
- [ ] Confirm team consensus on the selected firm
- [ ] Document the selection rationale
- [ ] Prepare to notify all firms of the decision

Phase 4: Award the Contract and Begin the Partnership

Action 4.1: Prepare the Contract

Before signing, confirm the contract clearly addresses:

Element	What it should cover
Scope of work	What the LSI will do — organized by school or building
Timeline	Key milestones and deadlines per site
Deliverables	What you will receive (plans, reports, recommendations) per project
Fees and payment schedule	How much, and when
Success criteria	How you will know the LSI is delivering
Communication and governance	How often you meet, who decides what
Change management	How scope changes are handled and priced
Insurance and liability	Coverage requirements
Confidentiality	What stays confidential
Termination provisions	What happens if the relationship is not working

CHECKLIST — ACTION 4.1

- [ ] Request the contract template from district Purchasing/Legal
- [ ] Ask the selected firm for their standard agreement
- [ ] Compare both documents and identify areas for negotiation
- [ ] Have Legal Counsel review the final agreement before execution

Action 4.2: Notify All Firms of the Decision

Professional communication after selection protects your district's reputation and relationships.

- Call the winning firm first to confirm they accept the award
- Send the written award letter to the selected firm (see Appendix B)
- Send a written non-award notice to all other firms that submitted proposals — thank them and indicate that another firm was selected (see Appendix B)

- Offer brief feedback if non-selected firms request it (not required, but a professional practice)
- Keep contact information for all firms — you may work with them on future projects

CHECKLIST — ACTION 4.2

- [ ] Confirm the selected firm accepts the award
- [ ] Send the award letter to the selected firm
- [ ] Send the non-award notice to all other firms
- [ ] Offer feedback to non-selected firms on request

Action 4.3: Hold the Project Kickoff Meeting

Once the contract is signed, bring both teams together to launch the partnership. Suggested agenda:

1. Introductions and relationship building
2. Review of project vision, scope, and school-by-school timeline
3. Governance: who decides what, meeting cadence, escalation paths
4. Communication protocols
5. Expectations: what success looks like for both sides
6. First 30 days: specific next steps and deliverables

CHECKLIST — ACTION 4.3

- [ ] Schedule the kickoff meeting (1–2 hours) within one week of contract execution
- [ ] Prepare the kickoff agenda and materials
- [ ] Confirm attendance from both teams
- [ ] Conduct the meeting; document decisions and next steps
- [ ] Send meeting minutes to all attendees within 48 hours

Key Principles for Success

- **Vision first.** Let your district's educational vision drive the LSI selection — not existing vendor relationships, existing contracts, or price alone.
- **Process matters.** Taking time to define your vision, build your team, and develop clear criteria produces better proposals and better outcomes.
- **The LSI is a partner.** You will work with this firm for two or more years. Choose someone you trust and can communicate with openly.
- **School-by-school accountability.** Structure work and contracts so each building is a discrete, accountable project — not a vague district-wide promise.
- **Fair evaluation is rigorous evaluation.** Use the scorecard. Score independently. Don't let personalities or prior relationships bias your decisions.
- **Budget matters — but it is not everything.** A partner with stronger experience and process will deliver better long-term value than the lowest-fee option.
- **Accessibility and inclusion are not optional.** Design spaces from the start for all learners — including those with disabilities, sensory differences, and diverse learning needs.
- **Measure what matters.** Evaluate success through space utilization, educator adoption, instructional practice change, and stakeholder perception. Standardized test scores are not a valid measure of learning environment effectiveness.
- **Timeline is real.** A 2–3 month procurement timeline is reasonable. Do not rush the selection, but keep momentum.
- **Document everything.** Written records of your process, scores, and rationale protect your district if a non-selected firm challenges the award.

Appendix A: Timeline Template

Use this as a starting point. Adjust it based on your district's pace, state requirements, and project complexity.

Timeframe	Activities
Month 1, Weeks 1–2	Assemble the procurement team; secure leadership buy-in; verify state procurement compliance; check cooperative purchasing vehicles
Month 1, Weeks 3–4	Develop the scope of work (school by school); define evaluation criteria; create the RFQ document; Legal review
Month 2, Week 1	Build the prospect list; send invitations; open the question period
Month 2, Weeks 2–3	Firms prepare proposals; answer questions in writing; share Q&A with all firms
Month 2, Week 4	Receive proposals
Month 3, Weeks 1–2	Evaluate proposals using the scorecard (independent, then consensus)
Month 3, Week 3	Reference checks; finalist interviews
Month 3, Week 4	Final selection; award contract; notify all firms
Month 4	Contract execution; project kickoff meeting; begin Phase 1 assessment

Appendix B: Award and Non-Award Letter Templates

> Adapt these letters to your district's letterhead and have Legal Counsel review them before sending. Send the award letter only after the selected firm has verbally accepted, and send non-award notices on the same day.

B.1 Award Letter

[District Letterhead]

[Date]

[Firm Name]
[Attention: Primary Contact Name, Title]
[Address]

Re: Notice of Selection — Learning Space Integrator Services, [RFQ/RFP Number and Title]

Dear [Primary Contact Name]:

On behalf of [District Name], I am pleased to inform you that [Firm Name] has been selected to provide Learning Space Integrator services in response to [RFQ/RFP Number and Title]. The selection committee's decision followed a qualifications-based evaluation of all responsive proposals, reference checks, and finalist interviews.

This notice of selection is not a contract. The district intends to negotiate and execute a professional services agreement with your firm covering the scope of work, school-by-school milestones, deliverables, fees, insurance, and conflict of interest representations. [If applicable: This award is subject to approval by the Board of Education at its meeting on [Date].]

Please contact [Procurement Contact Name] at [Email] or [Phone] by [Date] to schedule contract discussions. We expect to hold a project kickoff meeting within one week of contract execution.

Thank you for the time and care your team invested in this process. We look forward to working together to create learning environments that serve every one of our students.

Sincerely,

[Name]
[Title]
[District Name]

B.2 Non-Award Notice

[District Letterhead]

[Date]

[Firm Name]
[Attention: Primary Contact Name, Title]
[Address]

Re: Selection Decision — Learning Space Integrator Services, [RFQ/RFP Number and Title]

Dear [Primary Contact Name]:

Thank you for submitting a proposal in response to [RFQ/RFP Number and Title]. After a qualifications-based evaluation of all responsive proposals [and finalist interviews], [District Name] has selected another firm for this engagement.

We appreciate the time and expertise your team brought to this process. The committee was impressed by the quality of the responses we received, and this decision was not an easy one.

If you would like brief feedback on your proposal, please contact [Procurement Contact Name] at [Email] by [Date]. [If applicable: Information about the district's protest procedure is available at [Location/Link]; protests must be submitted in writing by [Date].]

We will keep your firm's information on file and hope you will consider responding to future opportunities with [District Name].

Sincerely,

[Name]
[Title]
[District Name]